

“Sehnsucht”

as Democratic Praxis and Resource in Civic Adult Education

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Civic adult education faces a fundamental question

1

Polycrisis

overlapping ecological, economic
and political emergencies

2

Democratic erosion

institutions losing legitimacy and
reach

3

Social fragmentation

shared ground for dialogue
narrowing

4

Political powerlessness

and public anger, widely felt

How can learning processes reconnect personal experience with public responsibility and participation?

Three andragogical roots from Freire

The theoretical foundation this project builds on

Critical consciousness

Conscientização: A dialogical process in which people recognise the social and political conditions of their lives as historical and changeable, and act to transform them, uniting reflection and action into praxis

Freire (1970/2005, p. 17)

Critical dialogue

An encounter between people, mediated by the world, aimed at naming it. Naming means reading a situation critically, uncovering who holds power and what structures exclusion, with teacher and learner as co-investigators of shared reality

Freire (1970/2005)

Pedagogical love

An ethical and political commitment to the other person, grown from becoming able to love the world and people in their concrete, real existence (Freire, 1996/1998).

Pedagogical love is expressed in mutual respect that holds together reason, embodiment, politics, emotion and the beauty of the world and of knowledge (Barcelos, 2021).

It also involves accepting the other person without the will to change them (Vanderheiden, 2023).

*Freire (1996/1998); Barcelos (2021);
Vanderheiden (2023)*

Together, these three roots define the andragogical stance this project takes towards political longing.

Why this project engages Sehnsucht

Civic education easily turns into criticising, evaluating or rejecting people for the political positions they hold. This project assumes that such judgement does not open change, because it engages the position and leaves its motivational ground untouched.

Behind the wish for simple answers in a complex world, or for a leader who removes ambivalence and takes decision and responsibility away, lies a longing. Seeing it, hearing it and taking it seriously is the condition under which critical dialogue, and political transformation, can begin.

Conceptualising Sehnsucht

Six characteristics, after Baltes (2008), as reviewed in Vanderheiden (2025)

1

Utopia

of an unattainable ideal development

2

Incompleteness

the felt imperfection of a life

3

Triadic focus

past, present and future held together

4

Ambivalence

positive and negative fused — bittersweet

5

Reflection

an evaluative, self-examining function

6

Symbolism

attaches readily to images and narratives

“There is no real equivalent term for Sehnsucht in the Anglo-American language area.”

Vanderheiden (2025, p. 73)

Sehnsucht

German

forward-oriented, utopian, unrealised ideal

Saudade

Lusophone

anchored in the past or the absent

Viraha

Indian / Sanskrit

longing for union — a loved one or the divine

Struggimento

Italian

wistful, aching longing, distinct from mere nostalgia

Sehnsucht discloses the normative horizon of democracy

An orientation towards what is missing in the present:

Justice

unrealised

Belonging

insecure

Dignity

unrecognised

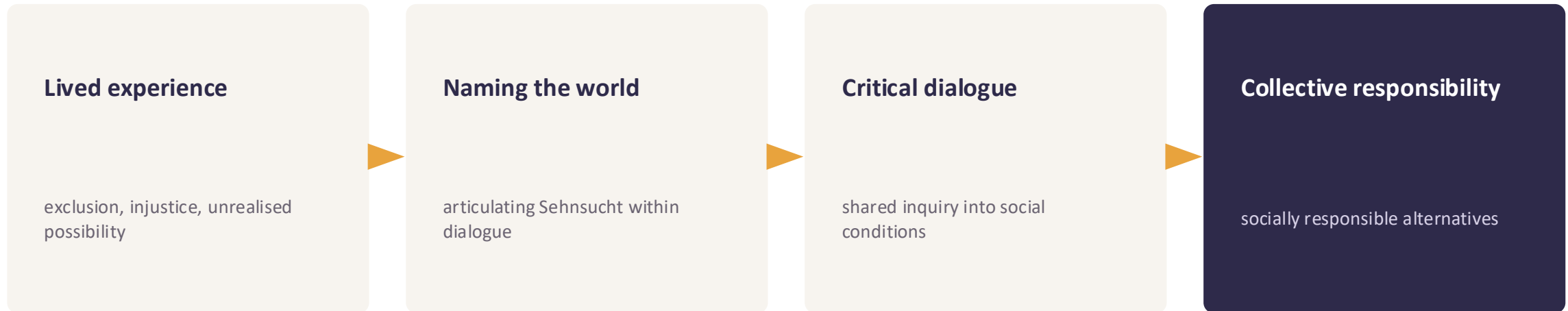
Participation

restricted

It makes visible the distance between lived experience and democratic commitments. The wish for a leader who resolves ambivalence and relieves the burden of decision belongs to this pattern. Recognising this longing before judging it opens the field for reflection and transformation.

Sehnsucht as a generative theme

From lived experience to conscientização/ critical consciousness/conscientisation (Freire, 1970/2005)



Engaging Sehnsucht pedagogically means naming the longing itself, not only the injustice it responds to. Political education that criticises or rejects such longings forecloses the dialogue conscientização requires (Freire, 1983).

Illustration from practice: S.P.I.E.G.E.L.

Sehnsüchte politisch integrieren, erforschen, gestalten und erleben lernen ("learning to politically integrate, research, shape and experience longings")

— Catholic Adult Education Rhineland-Palatinate, 2025

Sehnsuchtsmosaik

Mosaic of Longing

31

contributions

people articulate their own longings directed at political conditions

Sehnsuchts-Timeline

Timeline of Longing

10

historical figures

figures whose personal longing sparked a social or political movement

Sehnsuchtsatlas

Atlas of Longing

15

regions worldwide

longing shifts in meaning depending on the cultural environment one lives in

Kartenset

Card Set

70

cards

longing is bound to cultural concepts — diverse traditions presented side by side

Workshopreihe

Workshop Series

5

modules, 90 min each

how to work with Sehnsucht as a theme in political adult education

The Atlas shows that shared motifs of longing — security, belonging, freedom, an intact environment — take on very different meanings and urgency depending on geographic, cultural and political conditions, from Roda Verheyen (Germany, climate protection as a human right) to Nemonte Nenquimo (Ecuador, indigenous land rights).

On the Timeline, this dynamic becomes historical: Paulo Freire is one of the ten figures presented, alongside Olympe de Gouges, Simone Weil and Narges Mohammadi.

Sehnsucht operates as a forward-looking force within democratic life

Civic adult education benefits from spaces in which unfulfilled aspirations are articulated, examined critically and connected to public action.

It links individual motivation to institutional practice. Political change follows when longing is seen, heard and taken seriously, a condition that moralising appeals and pedagogies of shock rarely meet.

Questions & Discussion

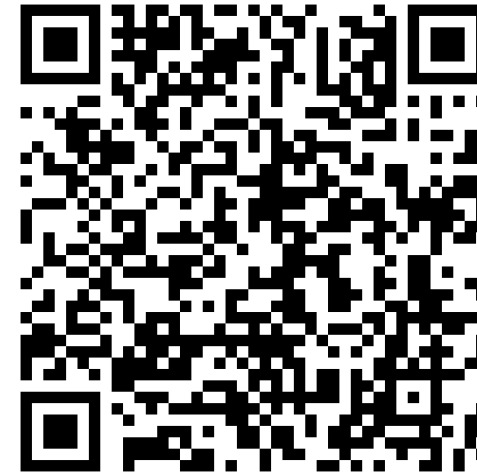
Thank you for your attention.

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Slides & further information



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